

Microdrive-Based External Hard Drives

Qrisma	Seagate
1" Portable Micro Drive	5.0 GB Pocket Hard Drive
16.24 (Out of 45)	17.56 (Out of 45)
6	5
NA	3600
NA	NA
NA	2
✓/✗	✓/✗
✗	Seagate Toolkit, drivers for Windows 98, user manual
46 x 64 x 12	70 (diameter) x 18
0.03	0.063
✗	✗
Retractable USB cable	Retractable USB cable
3	3.25
21.24	30.30
1	3
51.4	26.1
7.4	6.8
3.3	6.8
5.84	8
6.24	8
5.28	7
6.24	8
3.68	5
26.4	24
DNC	299
DNC	138
DNC	508
DNC	169
DNC	128
DNC	603
3024	696
1	1
1.55	0.94
6.32 (Out of 15)	12.50 (Out of 15)
9,500	4,800
43.80	60.36



- + Very small form factor
- Extremely slow



- + Inexpensive; good performance
- Average build quality

Best Buy Gold in this category. There is a catch, however: the size of desktop PC hard drives has increased, and 250 GB hard drives are common today. A 160 GB hard drive could therefore be insufficient.

Not far behind in the final score tally is the Seagate Pushbutton Backup 200 GB, priced at Rs 8,400. It has a feature set similar to that of the Gold winner, and even showed better performance. But price was the sore point, and this drive was therefore adjudged the winner of the Digit Best Buy Silver award.

MICRODRIVE-BASED EXTERNAL HARD DRIVES

With a USB drive, all you need to do is plug in the drive to a USB port, and you're ready to drag-and-drop files—it's so easy! Storage capacity is, of course, the problem. Though we're now seeing the development of USB drives with very large capacities, they're terribly expensive in terms of cost per MB.

For now, then, microdrive-based external hard drives are the solution. Every computer today comes with USB 2.0 ports: this has contributed a great deal towards popularising such drives.

This is a niche category, and only a few manufacturers make microdrives. We therefore received only three products in this category: the LaCie Carte Orange 6 GB, Qrisma 6 GB, and the Seagate 5.0 GB Pocket Hard Drive.

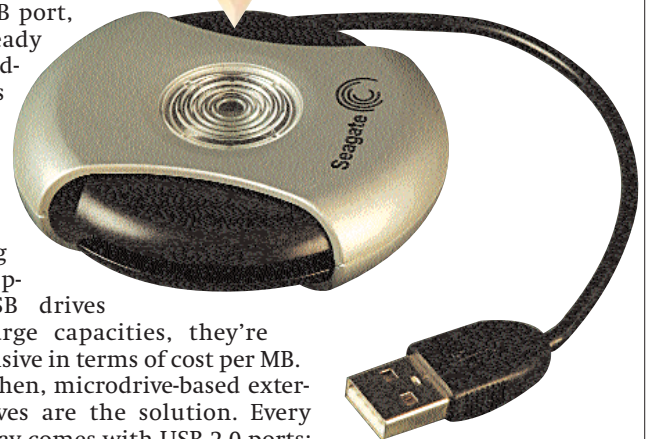
FEATURES Cables And Accessories

All the drives here use the USB 2.0 interface. Only the LaCie came with a USB extension cable. This proves very useful if the computer does not have front USB ports and if the area around the USB ports is congested. All the drives have retractable USB ports, and they can be swivelled by 90 degrees to accommodate the drives in difficult-to-reach places.

Other Features

The LaCie Carte Orange drive is credit card-shaped. It is quite rugged, as is the case with all the LaCie drives we received. Orange in colour and with a retractable USB connector, this one would surely be a hit with the ladies.

The Qrisma has a small form factor, and it's just a bit larger than the LaCie. The body is of black plastic, but it doesn't seem strong at all. The retractable USB connector pops out at the flick of a button at the front of the drive, but we found doing this a bit tricky—the button is quite hard to press.



Seagate
5.0 GB Pocket Hard Drive